

Mark Stringer

Three Fringe Shows, 2024-2026

Delivering the Impossible - The Biscuit Tin and the Biscuit - You Can Write a Book



Delivering the Impossible

Successful Ways of Seeing
Software Project Management

—
Mark Stringer

Apress®

Delivering the Impossible

By Mark Stringer - Apress, an imprint of Springer

Delivering the Impossible starts from a simple observation: most software projects that fail don't fail because of bad code. They fail because of a bad way of seeing the project in the first place. Point of view is worth eighty IQ points, and most of the tools project managers reach for, the detailed up-front plans, the fixed scopes, the sign off meetings, quietly make people worse at seeing what is actually happening.

The book argues that every software project is really two projects running at once. There is the idea value stream, how a proposal gets attention, funding and support, and that stream is weird: ideas get backed for emotional and political reasons, not because anyone has tested them. Then there is the product value stream, the thing the team actually has to build, which does not exist yet and has to be discovered. Most of the pain in a project comes from the gap between those two streams.

That gap opens up because projects happen in a swamp, not on solid ground. A mess of stakeholders, regulators, hidden constraints and competing interests influence the project. And no plan drawn up in a meeting room can anticipate them. The only way through is research, and the only way to make research honest is to get working software in front of real users as soon as possible. Even when it is embarrassing. That shifts a project from "push", where sponsors and specifications drive everything, to "pull", where user demand starts doing the steering.

Working software also surfaces the "pirate ship": the obvious problem on the horizon that everyone in the room can see and nobody wants to mention. This is because they know that raising the obvious issues will cause problems. Bosses often resist bad news because it threatens their own credibility, not caring so much what the effect will be on the project. Another way of seeing it: "bad news is data". Treating it that way, instead of as an attack, is one of the book's central arguments, aimed as much at bosses as at project managers.

Every project is a bet, and most of the machinery built around one, the methodologies, the certifications, the governance boards, is project management theater dressed up to make an uncertain bet look safe. The honest response is not to pretend the risk away. It is to break one big bet into many small ones through incremental delivery, and sometimes to admit the odds are bad enough that the project needs more money, more time, or a serious rethink rather than a quiet failure.

Underneath many if not all the problems that projects experience is one habit of mind the book keeps coming back to: symmetrical thinking, the unconscious assumption that a project should deliver all of it, exactly as first imagined, forever. Real delivery is asymmetrical: some features, for some people, for a while, close enough. The biscuit tin is not the biscuit. Agile, done properly, is a structured way of injecting some into people's desire for all.

None of this lets project managers off the hook, and it doesn't let bosses off it either. The book ends where it starts: all projects are swamps, every project is a bet, and the job is not to make the swamp disappear. It is to see it clearly enough to deliver the possible, instead of the fantasy.



MARK STRINGER

DELIVERING THE IMPOSSIBLE

A thick, horizontal red brushstroke underline that spans the width of the title, with a slightly textured, hand-painted appearance.

**A Short Talk About How to
Rule the World**

“I didn’t expect this to be so interesting”

Delivering the Impossible

A Short Talk About How to Rule the World

Clover Studio, Greenside @ Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket, Edinburgh EH1 2PG
Edinburgh Festival Fringe, 12-24 August 2024 (not Sun 18th) - 1:45pm, 45 minutes

Software is eating everything: food, romance, television. The people who know how to manage making it - Bezos, Musk, Zuckerberg - end up running the world. This was Mark Stringer's first full Fringe run, built from a working software project manager's point of view: projects treated as bets, struggling delivery as a pirate ship nobody wants to look at, bad news treated as data rather than a threat. The talk argues that a better point of view is worth more than a better method, and that most software isn't so much finished as helped to escape into real use. Forty-five minutes of the argument that later became his book, *Delivering the Impossible*, tried out loud on a small Edinburgh audience before it was tried out in print. One audience member called it 'knowledge about project management I wouldn't acquire elsewhere.'

Main points

- Point of view is worth 80 IQ points: how you see a project matters more than which method you follow
- Every project is a bet, not a guaranteed outcome
- Struggling projects have a 'pirate ship' everyone in the room is ignoring
- Delivery is less about finishing software and more about helping it escape into real use
- Agile practice injects 'some' into people's desire for 'all'
- Project management isn't really about exact promises; it's about delivering value under uncertainty

Mark Stringer



The Biscuit Tin and the Biscuit

Biscuits are delicious. Creativity is hard.



**GREENSIDE AT
RIDDLE'S COURT**
VENUE 16

'Encapsulating the spirit of the fringe'
Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket,
Edinburgh, EH1 2PG

**CLOVER
STUDIO**

The Biscuit Tin and
the Biscuit
11TH — 23RD August
18:20 (0hr 45m)

£10.00 (Full) £5:00 (Concession)

BUY TICKETS HERE



fringe
The Edinburgh Festival

The Biscuit Tin and the Biscuit

Biscuits are delicious. Creativity is hard.

Clover Studio, Greenside @ Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket, Edinburgh EH1 2PG

Edinburgh Festival Fringe, 11-23 August 2025 - 18:20, 45 minutes (previewed at Brighton Fringe, 9 May 2025)

A biscuit tin is not a biscuit. An idea, a plan, a description of the thing you mean to make is different from the thing itself, and the gap between them is where all the difficulty - and all the interest - lives. Mark Stringer's second show follows that gap through writing, project management, language learning and improvisation, arguing that creativity is emotional labour, not just talent: frustration, perfectionism, hesitation, the urge to stop. It borrows the structure of Bake Off - where getting better doesn't mean getting more confident, it means arriving at new and more elaborate forms of not knowing - and applies it to any kind of making. It proposes three ways through: know your real capacity, have an honest conversation with the work, and sometimes just decide. 'Fuck it, I am going to do this.'

Main points

- The biscuit tin is the idea; the biscuit is the real thing you actually make
- Turning one into the other always produces emotion, not just technical difficulty
- Getting better at something doesn't mean feeling more confident - it means facing new kinds of not knowing
- Perfectionism and 'agreed activity' are two of the most common ways people avoid real progress
- Know your actual capacity rather than setting impossible targets
- Have a real conversation with the work instead of forcing it or avoiding it
- Some progress only happens after a decisive, unglamorous commitment

YOU CAN WRITE A BOOK!



**GREENSIDE AT
RIDDLE'S COURT**
VENUE 16

'Encapsulating the spirit of the fringe'
Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket,
Edinburgh, EH1 2PG

**CLOVER
STUDIO**

**You Can Write A Book!
(Mark Stringer)**

17th – 29th August (No Show 23rd)

18:20 (50 mins)

BUY TICKETS HERE



**Edinburgh
fringe**

You Can Write a Book

Clover Studio, Greenside @ Riddle's Court, 322 Lawnmarket, Edinburgh EH1 2PG

Edinburgh Festival Fringe, 17-29 August 2026 (not Sundays) - 18:20, 50 minutes - £10 / £5 concession

Mark Stringer has a book out and doesn't know how to market it. His first idea for the show's title was Please Buy My Book; he decided that was a bit on the nose. So instead, in fifty minutes, he talks to a room of strangers about how they could write a book too - using the same ideas about drafts, hesitation and turning ideas into real things that got his own book written, and that carried his last two shows at the Fringe. Where last year's show argued that the idea of a thing and the thing itself are made of different stuff, this one asks the audience to close that gap themselves: everyone in the room actually writes something, instead of just hearing about writing. Part sales pitch, part masterclass, part continuation of an argument that started with a biscuit tin.

Main points

- In fifty minutes, the audience leaves with real, usable ideas about how to start a book
- Continues the two-show arc: last year was the idea of the book, this year is making it
- Everyone in the room actually writes something during the show, rather than just hearing about writing
- Draws on the techniques Mark used to build the show itself: talking ideas out loud, shitty first drafts, rehearsing to near-empty rooms
- Doubles as a way of talking about Delivering the Impossible without directly asking people to buy it